

by aficionados.

Another interesting finding was that audiences in the south were underserved, though the region had three franchises. With only English commentary, there was not enough affinity towards the matches. Though people were watching, it needed higher levels of engagement. Having commentary in the local language and dialects deepens engagement. Cut to the present where the feed is available in 12 languages and dialects (including English, Hindi, Tamil, Marathi, Bhojpuri, Bengali, Telugu, Malayalam, and Haryanvi).

"This year, we have seen a surge in viewership in Kerala, where cricket is not necessarily the first game. It is the effect of Malayalam commentary, emergence of Sanju Samson (a Kerala boy) and higher penetration levels of Star Sports," says Gupta.

20 | In IPL 2024, television and digital had a viewership of more than 500 million each. Personalisation was the result of recognising that audience behaviour varied on both mediums. "The holy grail is to serve each fan differently or a hyper-personalised broadcast for each game," says Gupta. This is where the concept of consumer cohorts starts to make sense. According to him, the three questions on defining the consumer base—who, why, and how—are hugely critical.

From a strategic point of view, the flywheel effect (building momentum through a gradual process) is an important component. In this context, acquiring consumers, deepening engagement levels with them, and retaining them from one game to another, becomes crucial. The large audience base that the IPL already has is broken into four distinct cohorts. The first are the cricket connoisseurs who watch about 50 matches. Then, there are the socialising fans, for whom staying updated about IPL is important to establish

POWER PLAY

8-12

YEARS

► Kids broadcast called **Motu Patlu**, where two animated characters commentate and is custom made for those in the above age segment

₹16,348

CRORE

► IPL rights for the 2018-22 period by **Star India**, which was later acquired by **Disney** before getting merged with **Reliance Industries' Viacom18**

₹48,390

CRORE

► The amount for which IPL rights were acquired for 2023-27

4

COHORTS

► To deepen engagement levels, IPL's existing large audience base is segmented into cohorts

the right social connections. This group watches 25-35 matches. The third cohort is big-event watchers who come to watch for a Mahendra Singh Dhoni or Virat Kohli. The last one is the "light fans" who have set viewing patterns and cricket serves as an entertainment need. In terms of numbers, the first cohort accounts for 25% of viewership but watches 70 minutes of each game. "The kids will be in the sampler set (that's about 15%) where entertainment is the driver. We want to constantly drive upgradation and get them to consume more," explains Gupta.

For advertisers, breaking down viewership into these cohorts throws up multiple options. Publicis' Ravi Bhaya says viewer communities are formed around specific teams, players, and moments. "Casual weekday fans behave very differently from weekend superfans and that allows advertisers to tailor content and messaging to each. By identifying these refined cohorts, brands can reduce wastage, improve engagement, and deliver relevance at scale," he explains.

Technology is at the core of this but equally critical is the ability to innovate and the magic of consumer insights. Business strategist and marketing expert, Lloyd Mathias says identifying specific consumer groups based on geography, gender, or income groups on digital is a game-changer. "Through technology and innovation, the same feed can look different in two locations. Now, zeroing in on smaller advertisers is possible, just like how Google and Meta do it." To Gupta, each minute of engagement is important regardless of how intense or predictable a match is. "We need to think ahead and move to the next match. At each stage, we must layer data with human intelligence," he says. **BT**

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